

ALIQUIPPA TOWN HISTORY

What do the famous composer Henry Mancini, former U.S. Surgeon General Jesse Steinfield, and NFL Hall of Famers Tony Dorsett and Mike Ditka have in common? They all grew up in the humble town of Aliquippa.

While some believe that its name is derived from the Seneca Indian Queen Aliquippa, the town's moniker was actually chosen by P&LE Railroad in 1879 while constructing their rural stations. A year later, the railroad built an amusement park near Aliquippa station called Aliquippa Park. A village emerged around the park, followed by a lumberyard and other industry. In 1891, the Borough of Aliquippa was incorporated.

Around the turn of the century, Vulcan Crucible Company set up shop to produce high grade tool steel. About 150 men worked in its open hearth furnaces and rolling mills. But Aliquippa is best known as the former home of Jones and Laughlin Steel Company—one of the most productive steel plants of the 20th Century. In a move that expanded its Pittsburgh operations, J&L bought all the flat land along the Ohio River in Aliquippa—including Aliquippa Park—and built a new plant in 1907. J&L preserved the park's dance hall by moving it across town to serve as the borough's main office building.

J&L's first blast furnace in Aliquippa began producing iron in 1909 and by 1919, a total of five furnaces were cranking out one million tons of pig iron a year. Steel production followed with three Bessemer converters, and 488 coke ovens began processing half a million tons of coke per year. For the next 60 years, J&L expanded along the Ohio River in Aliquippa and along both sides of the Monongahela River in Allegheny County. With the advent of the automobile, steel production soared in the 1920s. By the '30s, Aliquippa's population maxed at 27,000, making it Beaver County's largest per capita town—leading to a housing boom along the borough's terraced hillsides.

As World War II ensued, J&L broke global production records, even coveting the Army Navy "E" Award for outstanding efficiency. Steel from Aliquippa was used on barges that landed on Iwo Jima and Normandy, and provided armor for General Patton's tanks to invade Nazi Germany.

The steel industry's collapse in the 1980s led to J&L's closing—a major economic loss that has rippled through the region. But present day initiatives are being undertaken to rejuvenate Aliquippa—including the Beaver County Corporation for Economic Development, Aliquippa Alliance for Unity and Development, West Aliquippa Heritage Committee and Uncommon Grounds.

The Ohio and Beaver rivers have played an important part in the development of Beaver County, spawning many unique river towns, each with a personality and character all its own. Today, each of these river towns shares a common focus on family values, hometown pride, economic growth and historic preservation.

The purpose of the Beaver County Community Walking Maps project is: 1) to promote health and exercise among the residents of the various river towns; 2) to highlight points of interest within each community; and 3) to promote community pride among all residents of the county. Through these maps, we hope people will see Beaver County as a collection of welcoming neighborhoods, all connected by common goals of economic progress, community pride and historical preservation.

THE RIVER TOWNS OF BEAVER COUNTY



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BEAVER COUNTY RIVER TOWN Walking Maps



ALIQUIPPA

PENNSYLVANIA

ALIQUPPA WALKING MAP

POINTS OF INTEREST

- 1 P&LE RAILROAD STATION
Station Street
- 2 UNION MEMORIAL
corner of Station Street
& Franklin Avenue

- 3 ALIQUPPA CENTENARY PARK
340 Franklin Avenue
- 4 UNCOMMON GROUNDS CAFÉ
380 Franklin Avenue

- 5 CITY BUILDING
581 Franklin Avenue
- 6 B.F. JONES
MEMORIAL LIBRARY
663 Franklin Avenue
- 7 FIRE STATION
1499 Kennedy Boulevard

1 Mile Route
2 Mile Route
3 Mile Route

